



Google Reader Notifier

A free and open source system tray, Notifier tells you of unread items in the RSS feed of the reader.

Open source Symbian

The Symbian foundation recently released an open source software package, the first in its plan to eventually make the entire operating system open source.

Geek life

While Elephants Dream was a short film, Valkaama is a full feature film being developed in Finland. Content for the movie has already been shot and subsequently published on the project's home page. Everyone is encouraged to contribute to the post-production process in order to complete the movie. The movie is near completion and the community is currently working on the music score. The community's work flow is managed quite well by constantly updating a list of work to be done for the film. Currently, apart from the music score, there is some amount of compositing left according to the list. Any takers? Community members discuss the work and ways to approach it in the forums.

The Digital Tipping Point is another such collaborative project. It's a documentary about open source. What better subject matter to be showcased via an open movie, right? The raw footage for the film consists of hours and hours of interviews. This presents a really good opportunity for wannabe editors to snip it into meaningful content. When the final product is released, it's bound to be a tight film, thanks to so many heads involved in the post production process.

Open source cinema also involves the remixing culture that is pretty common in music, and is catching up in the images/pictures space. The idea is to create original clips of video and offer it to the community to remix and republish. Some of these mashups make for some interesting viewing. However, for this trend to catch on there are a few hurdles. Video editing is not everybody's cup of tea and besides, meaningfully using canned clips requires quite a creative bent of mind. The hotspots for open cinema are opensourcecinema.org, freecinema.org, and straycinema.com. Be sure to watch "A remix Manifesto 2.0" on opensourcecinema.org – an open source documentary about copyright and remix culture. Created over a period of six years, the film features the collaborative remix work of hundreds of people.

Eat, sleep, DRINK open source

Right next to the open source kitchen sink (if ever there will be one), is the idea for open source beverages. Now you've made drinks at home, right? As children, come summer, we all remember making a cool batch of Rasna. But can you make Coke or Pepsi? Nope, you can't. Perhaps

the same gripe drove people to come up with the concept of open cola. A cola for which the recipe is openly available for anyone to modify or improve. But the project started off, not as a backlash, against big cola but as a promotional tool for FOSS. The idea was such a hit that the cola by itself sold more than 1,50,000 cans. The company backing the project became more famous as a cola company than as a company formed for the promotion of open source concepts.

Soon, open source tentacles extended further into the beverage kingdom and entangled themselves on to Free Beer. Before you get excited the 'free' here is like the one in Free Speech; not beer that you don't have to pay for. As they say, there's no such thing as a free beer, but here at least the recipe is free! The concept came about when a group of students from the IT University of Copenhagen decided to take licencing frameworks from the digital world and apply them to an analogue, real-world product. The recipe for Version 1 contained a South American stimulant that gives a caffeine hit to counter the drowsy effects of alcohol, or so the creators

hope. The recipe is published under the Creative Commons licence, which means that any brewing enthusiast can brew his or her own batch so long as the new recipe is published along with the beer. Similar projects came about later; one was a Doppelbock (dark type beer) backed by flying dog brewery (called the Open Source Beer Project), while another one was backed by Brewtopia. The Brewtopia project from Australia took the open source concept even further by letting customers own part of the company. They are even consulted on important

THE BUNNY STORY

Following the release of Elephants Dream, the Blender foundation released a second animated film called Big Buck Bunny and an open game titled Yo Frankie. In the movie, bunny is harassed by three rodents (Frank, Rinky and Gamera) who are bullies. After a particularly dreadful event, Bunny sets out for revenge. The game too is based on the universe created in the movie and follows the character of Frank. The Blender institute, that was instrumental in these two projects, was created as a division of the foundation to specifically create open content films and games.



decisions regarding their beer with a strange name – Blowfly.

Mod away

Perhaps the most interesting field touched by open source is hardware, since its so diametrically opposite to the culture's software origins. For long, hardware manufacturers have had those little stickers across the seams of their products, exalting the warning "do not open, warranty void if seal broken". It's quite clear that they don't want you to fiddle with their product

or modify it in any way; even if you're resourceful enough to modify it to make it better. Thus enters open source hardware – designed to be physically modified or reprogrammed to make it easy to install custom firmware and software to create entirely new products. The way this works is by the sharing of schematics, hardware design, PCB layout data and the free release of any other information that will help further development, such as the bill of materials. The idea behind this is the same as with software; opening up development will see innovation in never before seen ways.

The spectrum that open source hardware covers is huge. It includes small programmable gadgets, do-it-yourself kits, and a host of other modular devices. The

field spans from machine tools to robotics to wind turbines. There is even open source chip-processor architecture for graphics cards and core logic design for CPU cores. Many of these projects have gone on to great success, many have not seen the light of day, but all have given the community surrounding them a great deal of learning.

Take the case of the Open Graphics Project (OGP), which aims to design architectures and standards for graphics cards which will be used



Elephants dream post



Release your own cinematic masterpieces into the open world. If you want to release the creative bug in you, a good place to begin is makeinternettv.org. There are other such sites that offer tutorials on publishing video content online under a creative commons licence. As for publishing vehicles, you of course have YouTube, which has a lot of CC licensed material. And then there are more specific CC oriented video publishing websites such as revver.com, blip.tv and ourmedia.org. Check them out!